

KF30 Meeting Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Mindfulness and meditation training teaches us how to step back from the clamor of our minds and emotions. We are then free to fully engage with the reality presented to us rather than compelled to impose our ideas of what we imagine life should or shouldn't be. By practicing mindfulness and meditation, we learn not to fear the present moment, ourselves, or others; instead, we observe reality with compassion and calm ourselves as we would calm a distressed child. We are developing skills that help us circumvent the traps and snares of the hunter, who, as we learned in KF lesson 12, tries to manipulate us with fears and cravings. With practice, our choices will become less influenced by the compelling need to feel safe, to restore our pride, to generate and flee self-hate, to have things go our way, and to save our Idol's life.

Calming Breath

1. Prepare

Assume a meditation posture, or you may wish to lie down. Settle into this experiment. *(Pause)* Begin with a silent prayer for peace within yourself and in your life. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. Scan for tension

As you inhale, explore your body for tension. You might start with your feet and ankles, and on the exhale, try to release any tension you find. Continue to breathe deeply, and move your attention to other parts of the body. Remember to explore your face. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. Use sound

Sing the word *CALM* as you exhale. Use tone to vibrate your body and bring it into a state of rest. Here's an example of how that might sound. *(Give an example)* Feel your body soften and relax. Voice the long “ahm” sound for one breath and then rest for the next breath. As you practice, you may wish to scan your body again. Continue at your own pace for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

4. Use breath

When you feel ready, let go of singing the word out loud. Just whisper the word or allow it to flow in

your mind with your breath. As you continue to scan and release body tension, explore a rhythm that works for you. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now, release the word altogether. Breathe deeply and occasionally sigh with a long exhaling breath. Continue to release any tension in your body and mind. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

5. Rest

Without strain or thought, rest in the stillness for one minute. If you notice your mind wandering, use the word *CALM* to draw it back into stillness. To rest in stillness means to poise your mind in an attentive space without images, words, or thoughts. Breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause and gently stretch. Open your eyes and re-engage with the meeting. *(Pause)*

We are training our minds and bodies to relax on command. It is out of a calm inner peace that we find our path to orientation.

This is our teaching from James: “For the fruit of orientation is planted in peace by those who make peace.”¹ *(Pause)*

Our hymn for this lesson is *Spirit of God, Descend upon My Heart*.

Teach me to feel that Thou art always nigh.
Teach me the struggles of the soul to bear,
To check the rising doubt, the rebel sigh.
Teach me the patience of unanswered prayer.²

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

KF Confession 7 describes the turning point toward healthy living:

We commit now to live in reality, choosing to believe rather than judge.

Let’s look again at what we have been learning.

1. Suffering is part of the rebirth and growth process

In the last lesson, we looked at the worksheet titled **Suffering: An Opportunity to See Yourself**. This worksheet is designed to help you see how you yourself generate much of your own suffering. Self-generated suffering is a colossal waste of your powerful energy, especially since this kind of suffering is simply the result of hurt pride. Once you can accept this, you can redirect that powerful energy toward actualizing your real growth and potential.

When you realize that suffering can be productive, you can choose to make friends with whatever suffering may be yours. For example, Nancy often suffers from the stretching challenges of this

ministry, but at the same time she recognizes the value of that suffering. She sees herself becoming the person she has always wanted to be, doing what she is designed to do. She can now declare the glory of God more effectively in this world, which is her real business. By making friends with her suffering and accepting the challenges that are necessary for her training, she offers her karis gift to God.

What challenges are standing before you? Could they be invitations to offer a karis gift to God?

2. You begin with yourself

As we learned in KF29, research has shown that through repeated action, learning, memory and, Nancy would add, through orienting your energy, you can change the quality of your life and how you interpret your experiences, including experiences that you carry with you from your past. We know that this is true. In KF, we regularly see people change the quality of their lives through new understanding, mindful observation, and repeated oriented action.² Your KF training gives you the power to cultivate this change.

3. Learn wisdom

It is a reality that we all live in a created material world, and each one of us is subject to the cycles of this material world. Every choice of action or inaction plants a seed that becomes a cause, and that cause produces an effect. So, when you make a choice of any kind, you set in motion a cycle of cause and effect. In Karis Fellowships, you are learning to live the kind of life that frees you to make wise choices in every area. When present stresses urge you to return to old misoriented patterns of relieving tension, you can compassionately acknowledge your stress and yet make different choices. With wisdom from above, you can learn new patterns of thought and behavior that will support and perpetuate your progress.³

4. Cycles are a reality

There is a time to work and a time to play. There is a time to act and a time to rest. There is a time to plant and a time to harvest.⁴ Does this sound familiar? The problem is that our pride does not want to recognize or submit to cycles. If we judge a particular timeline for our healing to be good, right, or fair, we may become frustrated when we do not experience healing within that time frame. This prideful attachment to a certain timeline inevitably creates disappointment. When we are oriented, however, we practice non-judgmental awareness in every area of our life, including the cycles of our healing, and we do not attach to a particular timeline for achieving our expectations. We rejoice in the truth of what we are learning right now. We re-parent and develop our souls today, and we set aside time for healthy rest, play, and laughter in the midst of all of our cycles.

5. Pride interferes with cycles

When you are resisting a cycle of life, whether one of training, rest, effort, or self-nurture, you might check out the **Suffering Worksheet**. The questions under PRIDE and THE MIRROR can help you recognize non-productive patterns. Are you pushing something because you judge a certain timeline to be best? Are you resisting something out of fear or laziness even though an opportunity is standing before you? Could pride or the fear of hurt pride be driving you to force, manipulate, and grab control, or to neglect, resist, and give up? Does pride prevent you from appreciating the effort and progress that you have made?

Our prayer might go something like this:

*Dear Creator, who understands the cycles of suffering, help me make the most of the cycles of my life.
(Repeat)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

The Bible teaching for this lesson is a cornerstone concept of Karis Fellowships training. Our passage is from the Gospel of Mark, chapter 4, and follows the Parable of the Sower, in which Jesus compares our souls to soil.⁵ Good seed is planted, but the outcome of the seed is determined by the quality of the soil. Seeds fall on the road, on rocky soil, on soil full of weeds, or on cultivated soil, and each type of soil will produce a different outcome. If you want to know the quality of the soil of a person's soul, just throw some seed out there and see what happens.

Now let's look at Nancy's translation of **Mark 4:28–29**.

²⁶And Jesus was saying, "In the same way the kingdom of God is like a man throwing seed onto the earth;²⁷ and he lies down to sleep at night and wakes up in the morning, and the seed sprouts and grows up in a way that he cannot see or understand. ²⁸The earth, acting out of its own volition, bears fruit—first the grass, then the ear, then the full grain in the ear. ²⁹And when the fruit yields up, immediately the farmer sends in the sickle because the harvest is at hand."

Take a deep breath.

In this passage, Jesus is teaching about the cycles of cause and effect in the kingdom of God. Whenever you invest in the kingdom, you get more in return. You cannot always see or understand how this works, but you know that if you plant quality seed in the prepared soil of your life, you can expect quality results. God has created a power within all seed that, given the right environment, makes things happen. Your business is to provide an environment that will accommodate, protect, and nourish the seed of oriented choices that you plant. Just as farmers prepare soil to nurture the potential of natural seed, you can cultivate a life that nurtures the potential of your oriented seed. Once you have prepared that soil and planted your seed, you can rest while the soil and the seed together do this mysterious thing called *produce*. When the harvest is ripe, you can confidently, without hesitation, reap what you have sown. By cooperating with God's way of doing things, you become the cause of your own abundance.

In the karis economy of the kingdom of God, the cycles of cause and effect operate at two different levels. This economy is built on trust, not law. Level One is the foundation that we must lay before we can progress to Level Two, but our goal is to live at both levels concurrently. At the first level of the karis economy, the cause produces an effect that is fairly predictable, but at the second level, the effect cannot be predicted, so living at the second level requires a more developed quality of trust.

Let's take a closer look at these two levels.

Level One: Preparing the soil

At Level One of the karis economy, we learn to give the gift of just trying to do things God's way. When you commit to living at this first level, you are choosing to do these three things:

1. **Obey kingdom law**—learn God's kingdom law of orientation and obey it.
2. **Cultivate more orientation**—learn what orientation feels like and looks like, and mindfully act in ways that cultivate it.
3. **Choose life**—avoid misoriented behavior.

When you practice these things, you become a cause that produces a predictable effect. You prepare the soil of your life for a harvest of peace rather than anxiety, and stability rather than chaos. This level lays the foundation upon which you build your karis life in the kingdom of God. At Level One, you begin to change the course of your outcomes.

Level Two: Planting the seed

The second level of the karis economy of cause and effect also involves three choices, but because the results of these choices cannot be predicted, this level requires a greater depth of trustworthiness and faith. At this second level of karis, you have already developed confidence in the power of your oriented, trustworthy life. You prepared the soil in Level One, and now you actively and intentionally plant seeds by giving your true gifts—the gifts God designed you to give. Your gifts carry spiritual power that stimulates and expands your circulation with God and with the Creation. Although you cannot predict how God will respond to your gifts, you trust that He will return to you only good and perfect gifts that will enrich your karis relationship with Him.⁶ You discover that His response is always immeasurably beyond all that you could ask for or imagine.⁷

At Level Two, you show God that you are trustworthy by practicing the following three things:

1. **Love your neighbor as yourself**—treat very well those who support you.⁸
2. **Do good to the trustworthy community**—support members of the community who are investing in their true glory.
3. **Act with kindness toward the world**—offer gifts of care and support to those outside the community.⁹

The cause at this higher level of karis is your growing relationship with God. He invites, and you respond by offering the gift of becoming more trustworthy. Your trustworthy choices invite Him into more relationship, and He responds with more gifts and invitations. The effect or outcome of this mutual generosity is unpredictable, but it will always be exactly what satisfies and fulfills.

In our passage from Mark, we see that the farmer does his part by giving something away. He faithfully throws his seed, and then he waits. He does not see or understand how the seed grows. That's what the second level of karis is like. We do oriented things, make oriented choices, and give without calculation or expectation. Marvelous things begin to happen, but we do not know how they happen. We cannot make direct correlations, nor can we predict how long it will take before we see the fruit. This is why karis requires trust—not trust in a certain predicted outcome, but trust in the Person of God.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Creator of the seasons, teach me how to plant that I might reap with joy. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

You might sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider trusting God to do above and beyond all that you can ask for, imagine, or control. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

Feelings

As you *consider trusting God to do above and beyond all that you can imagine or control*, breathe and recognize your feelings or lack of feelings. *(Pause)* You can learn to honor whatever you are feeling without allowing it to master you. *(Pause)* Recognize your experience with compassion, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Graciously allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness as you *consider trusting God to act on your behalf*. Observe your experience without judgment. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Use this time to explore, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider trusting God to do above and beyond all that you can ask for or imagine*. Observe your sensations. How does your body react to your feelings? Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider the possibility of trusting God to do for you what is beyond all that you can imagine*. Do you feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* What do you believe about God's efforts in your life? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something? Observe your experience as just information. You might process with a long exhaling breath, or with the Dragon Breath.¹⁰ *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore God's efforts in your life.
- Welcome the Holy Spirit and His creative power.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.

- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.¹¹

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I trust God's efforts in my life, I let go of the longing for power and getting my own way.
- As I trust God's efforts in my life, I let go of the longing for esteem and affection.
- As I trust God's efforts in my life, I let go of the longing for security and comfort.
- As I trust God's efforts in my life, I let go of the longing for perfection. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

(Optional) Continue to breathe while I test for further integration.

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time of training and healing. Hold us in the power of the cycle of karis as You guide us to our glory and to the truth about Your good intentions for us.¹² Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and design, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

Pray for KF members who work behind the scenes to make KF more efficient and accessible, and for those who give substantial financial gifts. Pray that God's gifts to these people will be above and beyond all that they could ask for or imagine.

¹ James 3:18.

² Maggie Macnab, *Decoding Design: Understanding and Using Symbols in Visual Communication* (How Books, 2008), 174.

³ James 3:17. See KF28.

⁴ Eccles. 3:1–8.

⁵ Matt. 13:1–23; Mark 4:1–20; Luke 8:1–15.

⁶ James 1:17.

⁷ Ephesians 3:20.

⁸ Luke 10:27.

⁹ Galatians 6:10.

¹⁰ See KF12.

¹¹ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

¹² Jer. 29:11.